otherwise been sold as slaves somewhere in the bazaars of Peshawar, Kabul, Kandahar or Central Asia. This was an essential part of my wandering surreal thoughts. But the ‘reverie’ wouldn’t end at that. When we asked the liberated women or children as to where they came from, and whether or not they would like to be escorted back to their families, they said that they would rather stay with our folks as there was no question of their being accepted back, not even by their parents. The traditional norms of Hindu and Muslim society of that period were very harsh. As per the strictly enforced rules, such unfortunate women and girls who had been violated, were no longer pure, and therefore, were unwelcome. So, we had another challenge ahead, that of rehabilitating these victims of destiny. Eventually, most of these destitute women and children made a new life for themselves in the vibrant, hard-working, secular and egalitarian communities of the Punjab, where they were given shelter and protection.

Historians who have written about the Punjab during this period have described these types of guerilla tactics used by Sikh bands against invaders carrying ill-gotten booty and slaves. This role – of some kind of a knight in shining armour – has been enshrined in my psyche, and therefore has become a part of me.

